

# Transformations

This document contains playtest material for the new [Grim Hollow](#) Transformation rules for 5th Edition. The rules herein are not finalised and are subject to change. Ghostfire's design team will conduct a development review, taking into account playtest feedback before proceeding with a formal editing pass to create the final form of these rules.

## Ruleset

The material contained within this playtest includes material taken from the System Reference Document 5.1 ("SRD 5.1") by Wizards of the Coast LLC and available at <https://dnd.wizards.com/resources/systems-reference-document>.

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## Providing Feedback

If you would like to playtest the monster hunter and provide your feedback, please use the following link to fill out the survey:

[Playtest Feedback Link](#)

The deadline for providing playtest feedback for this playtest packet is:

11:59 pm AEDT, February 4th, 2025.

## What's Included

This playtest pack explains transformations and how to use them in your campaign. Additionally, the following transformations are detailed:

- **Aberrant Horror**  
Nightmarish shapeshifters freed from mortal bounds to become living nightmares.
- **Lich**  
Undying rulers enthroned by forbidden magic, forging immortality at a terrible cost.
- **Seraph**  
Divinely chosen paragons embodying virtue and righteousness through celestial power.

# Transformations

Etharis teems with monsters of countless varieties. Some are born monstrous; others are created to be dangerous, malign, and cruel. Others still became monsters through accident or by choice. They became transformed.

What these transformed folks do with their newfound abilities—and how they deal with the monstrous urges that come with those abilities—might be the only delineation between whether they are seen as heroes or monsters.

## Why Transformations?

The following rules provide players and GMs with the tools to see the characters slowly become grim monsters. From dread-inducing werewolves to all-powerful liches, from bloodthirsty vampires to plane-touched seraphs, the following Transformations are available to characters.

The stories that permeate fantasy—and especially those stories of dark fantasy, horror, and the gothic—tend to come tinged with themes of transformation. Tales of innocent victims turning into the same monsters that attack them in the dark forest are as old as time itself. Magic wielders dabbling in forbidden arcana, paying with their very souls for the hubris, permeate most cultures.

Making these transformations—whether forced onto a creature or self-inflicted—viable within an RPG is a challenge. Sometimes the tropes are worked into a class itself, as we see with the blood-tainted sorcerer or the pact-making warlock.

These classes, however, often focus on only the positives. They show what these people have gained from their actions or backgrounds, but rarely do they capture the struggles that come with getting bitten by a lycanthrope, turned into a creature of the night by a vampire, or cursed with ghoul-hood by using the dangerous shadowsteel.

### Transformation Buy-In

Transformations can add a layer of storytelling and tension to a campaign. The tension of slowly turning into a monster is wonderful grist for the roleplaying mill, and being able to do things that a normal character cannot do is fun!

But there are risks as well. The power that comes with a Transformation, as well as the drawbacks they represent, can give transformed characters a perceived (or real) advantage over other characters. Likewise, a drawback can be the end of a character, or the entire party, at the most inopportune time.

In addition to the issues of power, the roleplaying and narrative consequences of transformed characters can be far reaching and devastating. A character whose

Transformation causes obvious supernaturally infused physical change is unlikely to escape the notice of a villager. Roleplaying those reactions every time can bog down a campaign; to ignore those reactions can make the point of the Transformation moot.

Before using Transformations in your campaign, discuss these issues so they do not harm the enjoyment of all the players and GM. While Transformations make for great narrative and mechanical opportunities, at no point do they provide an acceptable excuse to hurt the enjoyment of other players at the table.

## Beginning a Transformation

Individuals rarely choose to transform into monstrous beings. Most often, they have an affliction forced upon them. Foul curses, horrific experiments, and the diabolical machinations of fiends, vampires, and other dark agents are all examples of how a character might start a Transformation.

There are times, however, when a character may wish to begin a Transformation of their own volition. Perhaps they have succumbed to the lure of power, or they see it as the only way to achieve a greater goal. Regardless, the first step in any Transformation should involve a discussion between the player, the GM, and the rest of the players involved in the campaign. Intentions should be clearly stated, as certain Transformations may not be suitable for the campaign's setting or story.

The next step in a Transformation is to ensure you meet the transformation's prerequisites. These requirements, either narrative or game-mechanical, must be met for a character to start a Transformation. It is strongly recommended that these narrative prerequisites be attained through game play rather than through a backstory or other "offscreen" actions. However, a discussion for alternative avenues of meeting prerequisites can certainly take place.

Each of the Transformations that follows contains a section specifically focused on how a character might gain that Transformation, as well as how the first stages of the Transformation begin.

## Transformation Stages

Each Transformation has four stages. A new stage of a Transformation is reached when a certain milestone or trigger occurs. A list of potential general milestones or triggers is shown below. Additionally, each individual Transformation contains more specific triggers or milestones that can be used to dictate when a Transformation reaches a new stage.

## Universal Milestones or Triggers

The following milestones or triggers might cause the beginning of a Transformation, or they may cause a Transformation to move to a new stage.

- Undertaking an exceptionally evil (or good) act
- Completing an ancient ritual
- Obtaining a powerful artifact
- Being cursed by a dark agent
- Being exalted by a patron or god
- Making a pact with a powerful fey creature
- Stumbling upon an area infused with great power

## Class Levels and Transformation

### Stages

While Transformations are milestone- or trigger-based achievements, and Transformation stage comes with a Flaw, Transformations still represent a significant increase in power. For this reason, it is recommended that players and GMs use the Character Level/Transformation Stage table as a guide for when players should be able to increase to the next stage of a Transformation.

### Character Level/Transformation Stage

| Character Level | Transformation Stage |
|-----------------|----------------------|
| 1 - 4           | 1                    |
| 5 - 10          | 2                    |
| 11 - 16         | 3                    |
| 17 - 20         | 4                    |

## Transformation Boons and Flaws

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When the prerequisites for a Transformation are met and the Transformation begins, the character undergoing the Transformation is considered to be at Stage 1 of the Transformation.

At this point, the player should follow the instructions for selecting the Boons and Flaws for Stage 1. For some Transformations, the character may have to choose among various options. Similarly, some Transformations may require a character to select more than one Boon or Flaw at a given stage of Transformation.

# Aberrant Horror

A cloaked figure flees through the dimly lit city streets. The guards appear to have the upper hand, until she turns to greet them—a hulking mass of spines, claws, and gnashing maws.

Lightning cracks. A mad doctor bellows in triumph as a fresh corpse rises. With three fleshy tentacles sprouting from her back, the doctor's newest creation is complete. Thunder booms as the woman approaches the doctor menacingly, tendrils extended. Not all successful experiments end well.

Aberrant horrors are the result of a humanoid becoming an aberration. Able to break free from the physical restrictions imposed upon them by the natural laws of the world, they shift the components of their form at a whim. This makes aberrant horrors terrifying to behold, especially in battle. Many adversaries have been caught off-guard when a seemingly defenseless opponent suddenly grew rows of gruesome spines.

## Becoming an Aberrant Horror

Each aberrant horror is defined by one key question: what happened to them? Some individuals make pacts with ancient entities for powers that have unforeseen effects. Others awaken after defeating an unnatural monster, surprised that they survived, only to feel something writhing in their stomach. Many tropes of body horror can be used as inspiration for an aberrant horror.

Once your origin has been determined, you can consider what your character's motivations are regarding their Transformation. As their power grows and manifests, they may feel they have lost what makes them fundamentally themselves. Perhaps they decide to take revenge on the entity responsible for their transformation, or perhaps they perceive their transformation as a gift.

## Reversing Aberrant Horror Traits

Once the character reaches Stage 1 of the Aberrant Horror Transformation, the Boons and Flaws they've received cannot be removed by normal or even typical magical means. Some magic might slow or halt the mutations that the character endures, but magic on the level of the *Wish* spell is needed to completely remove the Transformation and its Boons and Flaws.

## Aberrant Horror Stages

At each stage of this Transformation, follow the instructions provided for that stage.

### Achieving a New Stage

To move from one stage to the next higher one in this Transformation, an event or some other notable occurrence tied to the story of the character should take place. The following events are suggestions for ones that might trigger a move to the next stage of the Transformation:

- Become exposed to magic of an unearthly or transformational nature
- Rest in the vicinity of a cursed item or site
- Offer prayers to an Aether Kindred and fulfil the quest they show you in your dreams
- Drinking the blood or other fluids of an Aberration that is still alive

### Aberrant Horror Stage 1

When you initially undergo the Aberrant Horror Transformation, you gain both Stage 1 Boons, and also gain the Stage 1 Flaw.

#### Stage 1 Boon: Aberrant Form

*Aberrant Horror Stage 1 Boon*

Your creature Type becomes Aberration in addition to any other creature type(s) you have.

Also, the first time you become Bloodied after a Short or Long Rest, you gain a number of Temporary Hit Points equal to your Proficiency Bonus Plus your Current Transformation Stage.

#### Stage 1 Boon: Aberrant Mutation

*Aberrant Horror Stage 1 Boon*

Your body can twist and reshape itself as you will it, changing body parts into dangerous weapons or useful tools, and regenerating after damage. These abilities are represented by Aberrant Mutations. You can manifest an Aberrant Mutation a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus Plus your Current Transformation Stage.

Each of these Aberrant Mutations last for 1 minute, and you can end them early by spending a Bonus Action to remove them or take on a different Mutation. The latter costs another use of this ability.

You regain all uses of the ability at the end of a Short or Long Rest.

**Chitinous Shell.** As a Bonus Action, you can grow a hard, crustacean-like shell. When you use this adaptation and are not wearing heavy armor, your

Armor Class increases by 2. While you maintain this shell, your Speed is reduced by 10 feet. This adaptation lasts for 1 minute. You may use a Bonus Action to end this Aberrant Mutation early.

**Eldritch Limbs.** As a Bonus Action, you can transform one or both of your arms into a weapon of thick muscle, sharp claws, or sharpened bone. When you make an attack, you can use this Aberrant Mutation. If you do, you gain the following features:

- You can use an Attack action to make a melee attack with your eldritch limb. When you manifest your eldritch limbs, decide if the attack does Bludgeoning, Piercing, or Slashing damage. That damage remains constant during this use of your ability. You are Proficient with this attack, which uses Strength or Dexterity for attack and damage.
- The attack does 1d8 damage of the type you chose.
- You cannot hold weapons, shields, or other items in your eldritch limbs.
- As a Bonus Action, you can make an attack with your eldritch limb.

This mutation lasts for 1 minute. You may also use a Bonus Action to end this Aberrant Mutation early.

**Slimy Form.** As a Bonus Action, you can cover yourself in a slippery slime. You make Escape checks with Advantage, and you can use the Dash action as a Bonus Action. You also gain Resistance to Acid, Fire, and Cold damage while in this form.

## Stage 1 Flaw: Unstable Form

*Aberrant Horror Stage 1 Flaw*

Your body becomes malleable and struggles to maintain any one physical shape. Upon completing a Long Rest after an adventuring day in which you took Hit Point Damage, you must roll 1d100 on the Unstable Form Table and apply the effects of the result, determined by your Transformation Stage. These effects last until you complete another Long Rest.

## Aberrant Horror Stage 2

When you reach Stage 2 of the Aberrant Horror Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 2 Boon, and also gain the Stage 2 Flaw.

### Stage 2 Boon: Efficient Killer

*Aberrant Horror Stage 2 Boon*

When you make an attack with your eldritch limbs, you can gain an added ability based on the damage type you have chosen. Those added abilities are listed below:

**Piercing.** You can launch a razor-sharp barb from your arm. These barbs are not weapons, but they have the Finesse and Thrown properties. On a hit, the target takes 2d6 + Strength or Dexterity modifier Piercing damage.

**Bludgeoning.** You can manifest a long tentacle, tipped with a hardened bone club. Your attack with your eldritch limb deals an additional 1d8 Bludgeoning damage. Also, the attack uses the Slow Weapon Property, which you have Mastery with. However, this attack is not considered a weapon.

**Slashing.** Your arm forms a row of viciously hooked claws and talons. Your attack with your eldritch limb deals an additional 1d8 Slashing damage. Also, the attack uses the Graze Weapon Property, which you have Mastery with. However, this attack is not considered a weapon.

## Stage 2 Boon: Writhing Tendrils

*Aberrant Horror Stage 2 Boon*

You gain the ability to grow long, tendril-like appendages out of your body. As a Bonus Action, these tendrils sprout from you. While you maintain these tendrils, you gain the following benefits:

- When a creature moves to within 5 feet of you, you can try to push it back as a Reaction. The creature must succeed on a Strength Saving Throw or be pushed back and its Speed is reduced to 0 until the end of its turn. The DC of the Saving Throw is 10 + your Strength modifier + your Transformation Stage.
- Your tendrils can protect you if you move. You can use a Bonus Action to Disengage.
- As a Reaction to being targeted with a melee attack, you can impose Disadvantage to all melee attacks made by that creature on that turn.

The tendrils last for 1 minute. You can use a Bonus Action to retract your tendrils.

You can use this ability a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all uses at the end of a Short or Long Rest.

## Stage 2 Flaw: Hideous Appearance

*Aberrant Horror Stage 2 Flaw*

Your appearance has grotesquely transformed. You may have turned into a hulking mass of flesh, adorned with countless eyes, or a bone-and-tusk-covered behemoth. Regardless of your true form, you're horrific to behold.

You can suspend this form and manifest the appearance of the humanoid you once were, but this is taxing and requires concentration. This form is not permanent, and moments of stress are likely to

reveal your true nature. Your true form may be revealed in the following situations:

- Becoming Bloodied
- Concentrating on a spell
- Gaining the Unconscious condition
- Entering hallowed ground
- Choosing to reveal yourself

In these events, or times of other extreme emotional or physical stress, a GM can call for a Constitution Saving Throw with a DC based on your current Transformation Stage:

| Stage | Constitution Save DC |
|-------|----------------------|
| 1     | 10                   |
| 2     | 13                   |
| 3     | 16                   |
| 4     | 20                   |

Non-evil creatures that witness your true form become instantly Hostile to you, unless the GM decides otherwise.

## Aberrant Horror Stage 3

When you reach Stage 3 of the Aberrant Horror Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 3 Boon, and also gain the Stage 3 Flaw.

### Stage 3 Boon: Terrifying Visage

*Aberrant Horror Stage 3 Boon*

Your mutations and unearthly appearance can unsettle even the bravest creatures. When you invoke your Aberrant Mutations or Writhing Tendrils, you choose one creature within 30 feet that can see you. That creature must succeed on a Wisdom Saving Throw or gain the Frightened condition for 1 minute. The DC for the Saving Throw is 10 + your Charisma modifier + your Transformation Stage. A creature that makes its Saving Throw is immune to this ability for 24 hours.

### Stage 3 Boon: Constricting Tendrils

*Aberrant Horror Stage 3 Boon*

*Prerequisite: Writhing Tendrils*

You gain an additional option for your Writing Tendrils ability.

As a Bonus Action, you can attempt to restrain a creature within 5 feet of you with your tendrils. The creature must succeed on a Strength or Dexterity Saving throw or gain the Restrained condition. The DC is 10 + your Constitution modifier + your Transformation Stage. This is the same DC for the creature to escape. The Restrained condition ends if you are Incapacitated, you move from your current position, if your tendril retract, or if you use your

tendrils to perform one of the other Writhing Tendril abilities.

## Stage 3 Flaw: Unstable Existence

*Aberrant Horror Stage 3 Flaw*

Magic causes your physical form to unravel. Whenever you roll a natural 1 or 2 on a Saving Throw against a spell or magical ability, you reveal your Hideous Appearance and must roll again on the Unstable Form table. If the result is less than your current Unstable Form effect, replace it with the new result.

## Aberrant Horror Stage 4

When you reach Stage 4 of the Aberrant Horror Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 4 Boon, and also gain the Stage 4 Flaw.

### Stage 4 Boon: Eldritch Aberration

*Aberrant Horror Stage 4 Boon*

*Prerequisite: Has Spell Slots*

You gain the ability to deliver jolts of magical energy with your Eldritch Limbs. Once per turn, when you hit a creature with an attack using your Eldritch Limbs, you can expend a spell slot to do 1d6 per spell slot of additional damage. You can choose for this additional damage to be of any of the following types: Acid, Cold, Fire, Force, Lightning, or Thunder. If any of these extra dice show a 6 when rolled, the creature also gains the Prone condition.

### Stage 4 Boon: Poison Tendrils

*Aberrant Horror Stage 4 Boon*

*Prerequisite: Writhing Tendrils*

You have Resistance to Poison damage and are Immune to the Poisoned Condition.

While your Writhing Tendrils are active, any creature you choose that starts its turn within 5 feet of you takes 3d6 Poison damage unless succeed on a Constitution saving throw. The DC for this saving throw is 14 + your Constitution modifier.

## Stage 4 Flaw: Entropic Abomination

*Aberrant Horror Stage 4 Flaw*

The very essence of magic and the effect of stress aggravates the unstable nature of your aberrant body. Whenever you fail a Saving Throw, or the first time you become Bloodied after finishing a Long Rest, you must roll on the Unstable Form Table. If the result is less than your current Unstable Form effect, replace it with the new result.

## Unstable Form Table

| Stage 1  | Stage 2  | Stage 3  | Stage 4  | Effect                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------|----------|----------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|          |          |          | 01 - 02  | The stress of your Transformation becomes too much. You die. You can be brought back to life with spells of level 5 or higher.                          |
|          |          | 01       | 03 - 04  | Your form becomes less hardy than normal. Your Hit Point Maximum is half your normal Maximum.                                                           |
|          | 01       | 02 - 03  | 05 - 06  | Your body starts to lose cohesion. You have Disadvantage on all d20 Tests.                                                                              |
| 01 - 05  | 02 - 03  | 04 - 06  | 07 - 24  | Your body's metabolism quickly drains your energy. You start the day with 2 levels of Exhaustion.                                                       |
| 06 - 10  | 04 - 06  | 07 - 24  | 25 - 32  | You have trouble processing what is happening around you. You have the Surprised condition.                                                             |
| 11 - 15  | 07 - 24  | 25 - 32  | 33 - 40  | Your limbs become weak. Your Speed (in all modes of movement) decreases by 15 feet and cannot be increased.                                             |
| 16 - 24  | 25 - 32  | 33 - 40  | 41 - 48  | Your body does not react quickly to mental commands. You cannot take Reactions.                                                                         |
| 25 - 32  | 33 - 40  | 41 - 48  | 49 - 56  | You are distracted by your changing form. You have Disadvantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks.                                                          |
| 33 - 40  | 41 - 48  | 49 - 56  | 57 - 64  | Your body becomes unable to fight off attacks. You have Disadvantage on Constitution saving throws.                                                     |
| 41 - 48  | 49 - 56  | 57 - 64  | 65 - 79  | You become clumsy. You have Disadvantage on Dexterity saving throws and Dexterity ability checks.                                                       |
| 49 - 56  | 57 - 64  | 65 - 79  | 80 - 87  | You lose blood or other vital fluids during your mutations. You cannot add your Constitution modifier to any Hit Point Dice spent to regain Hit Points. |
| 57 - 64  | 65 - 79  | 80 - 87  | 88 - 93  | Speaking is difficult. You can only utter one word during a turn. This does not hamper spellcasting.                                                    |
| 65 - 79  | 80 - 87  | 88 - 93  | 94 - 100 | No effect.                                                                                                                                              |
| 80 - 87  | 88 - 93  | 94 - 100 |          | Your lower limbs become more powerful. Your Speed increases by 5 feet.                                                                                  |
| 88 - 93  | 94 - 100 |          |          | Your flesh becomes more hardy. You start the day with 4 Temporary Hit Points per Transformation Stage.                                                  |
| 94 - 100 |          |          |          | Your body's systems are enhanced. You have Advantage on Death Saving Throws.                                                                            |

# Lich

The screams of souls torn from their bodies echo over the crackling of forbidden magic. A skeletal form rapidly stitches flesh and muscle to its frame, creating a seemingly living man – a man from an age and kingdom long gone. A man who has conquered death and risen again to enact his insidious will from millennia ago. The screams stop and are replaced with murmurs, as the corpses of the fallen arise as undead.

A lich is to their domain what a king is to their kingdom: undisputed, absolute power. Resting upon a throne of raw, world-rending potential, a lich comes as close to a god as any mortal could imagine. However, this awe-inspiring power comes at a dear price. Some liches favor arcane or diving magic, becoming peerless arcanists or hierophant. Some are warriors called memori liches who steal the life forces of their vanquished foes to make themselves nigh immortal.

Immune to the effects of age but not time, a lich is destined to exist without living for eternity. While this drives some liches mad and others to the extremes of pure evil, it makes them more acute in some areas and weakened in others. Time itself takes their faculties from them until they are a mockery of their past selves.

## Becoming a Lich

There are many ways to become a lich, each determining the type of lich the mortal becomes. The Ritual of Dread is one of the main methods for arcanists of Etharis. The process of this ritual is a well-guarded secret, entrusted to only a handful of mortals at any one time. The process of the ritual involves several despicable acts including murder, the brewing of a vile concoction, and even one's own death.

For memori liches, warriors of great renown who hope to break the cycle of death, the process is less involved but no less gruesome. The skull of a powerful vanquished foe serves at the focus of power, tipping off new opponents they are in for a hellish battle.

For hierophants, the call of the divine is equally strong to the call of mortality. Those who want to spend an eternity with power over both life and death in the name of a powerful divine source.

Regardless of the form of lichdom, the process of tearing one's soul from the body is most despised, for this process involves the sacrifice of something truly dear to a mortal, and no substitute will be accepted. For some, it is the death of a cherished loved one. For others it is a family legacy. Regardless of the sacrifice, unless the dread spirits deem it worthy, lichdom will not be granted.

## Reversing Lich Traits

The amount of raw magical energy that goes into becoming a lich means that undoing it is impossible. The only stage of being beyond lichdom is annihilation, and even that can only occur if both the physical form of the lich and its soul vessel are both destroyed.

## Lich Stages

At each stage of this Transformation, follow the instructions provided for that stage.

### Achieving a New Stage

To move from one stage to the next higher one in this Transformation, an event or some other notable occurrence tied to the story of the character should take place. The following events are suggestions for ones that might trigger a move to the next stage of the Transformation:

- Discover ancient and dark arcane knowledge
- Consume the soul of an exceptionally powerful spellcaster
- Build a monument to your power to serve as a giant arcane focus
- Create or lead an army of undead
- Meditate in the glow of a powerful arcane item or location
- Kill an Arch-Daemon or Arch-Seraph and absorb their power

### Lich Stage 1

When you initially undergo the Lich Transformation, you gain Undead Form Boon and one other Stage 1 Boon, and also gain the Stage 1 Flaw.

#### Stage 1 Boon: Undead Form

*Lich Stage 1 Boon*

You become an Undead in addition to any other Creature Type(s). If you are in an area under the effect of a Turn Undead ability, you cannot be excluded from the effects.

You also stop aging. You are immune to any effect that would age you, and you cannot die from old age. You do not require air, food, drink or sleep.

#### Stage 1 Boon: Lich Magica

*Lich Stage 1 Boon*

You can trade the soul in your soul vessel for increased magical power.

On your turn, as a Bonus Action, you can spend the charge in your soul vessel for one of the following effects.



- Regain a spell slot equal to or lower than your current Lich Stage.
- The next saving throw made against one of your spells is made with Disadvantage.
- Add 1d6 Necrotic damage per Lich Stage to the damage done to one creature by the spell.
- Heal 1d6 additional Hit Points per Lich Stage to the Hit points healed by the spell.

## Stage 1 Boon: Memori Lichdom

### *Lich Stage 1 Boon*

While your soul vessel is charged, you gain the following benefits to your weapon attacks:

- They count as magical.
- They have Advantage if taken as a Reaction.

Additionally, on your turn, as a Bonus Action, you can spend the charge in your soul vessel and spend a Hit Point Die to add that Die's result to the damage of the attack against one target.

## Stage 1 Flaw: Soul Vessel

### *Lich Stage 1 Flaw*

You have successfully torn your soul from your body and trapped it in a suitable object. The object must be a trinket or item no larger than 1 square foot in size. This item becomes your soul vessel.

**Soul Vessel.** A soul vessel is an enchanted vessel containing a lich's soul. Additionally, a soul vessel is a conduit for the lich to feed on captured souls. A soul vessel has the following statistics:

- Armor Class: 18
- Hit Points: 10 x your Character Level
- Speed: 0
- Damage Immunities: Poison, Psychic; Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from non-magical sources
- Damage Resistances: Cold, Fire, Lightning, Necrotic, Thunder; Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from magical sources

While a soul is stored in your soul vessel, the soul vessel is considered charged. The soul contained within the soul vessel must be from a creature whose Challenge Rating is equal to or higher than half your Character Level. The soul vessel can only contain one soul at a time.

To store a soul within the soul vessel, the lich must use an action or Reaction within 1 minute of a creature's death to capture the soul in the vessel. The dead creature's body must be within 60 feet of the vessel when the capture occurs.

If your soul vessel is reduced to 0 hit points, you must create a new one. Doing so takes a Long Rest. Until you do, you do not gain any of the benefits of having the soul vessel. Also, until you have a soul

vessel, you have Disadvantage on the first D20 Test you make after completing a Short or Long Rest.

If you are killed while you control a charged soul vessel on the same plane of existence, your soul vessel's charge is consumed and your body is reconstructed within 5 feet of your soul vessel 1 day later. If you are killed and your soul vessel is not charged, you are reanimated 7 days later instead.

## Lich Stage 2

When you reach Stage 2 of the Lich Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 2 Boon, and also gain the Stage 2 Flaw.

## Stage 2 Boon: Acolyte of Undeath

### *Lich Stage 2 Boon*

When you reduce a Humanoid to 0 hit points and it dies, you can use a Reaction to immediately transform it into a Zombie under your control. You can have three such creatures under your control at once. These creatures follow your verbal commands to the best of their ability.

## Stage 2 Boon: Binding Curse

### *Lich Stage 2 Boon*

You can compel a creature with a binding curse. As a Bonus Action, target a creature within 30 feet who can see you. If the creature fails a Charisma saving throw against a DC of 12 + your Lich Stage, it cannot move more than 30 feet away from you for 1 minute. Also during that time, your weapon attacks against the creature do an additional 7 (2d6) Necrotic damage.

You can use this feature three times, regaining all uses after completing a Short or Long Rest.

## Stage 2 Boon: Corrupting Magic

### *Lich Stage 2 Boon*

Whenever you kill any creature with a spell, you may apply an additional effect depending on the damage dealt. This ability cannot be used when you kill a Construct, Undead, or any creature without a soul.

Choose one of the following effects when you use this ability:

**Life Force.** As the soul of your enemy leaves their body, you siphon off part of their life force. You regain 1d6 hit points per your Lich Stage.

**Poison.** Target a creature within 10 feet of the killed creature. That creature takes 1d6 Poison damage per your Lich Stage.

**Exhaustion.** Target a creature within 10 feet of the killed creature. That creature gains one level of Exhaustion. A creature may only take one level of Exhaustion from using this power.

## Stage 2 Flaw: Hideous Appearance

### *Lich Stage 2 Flaw*

Your appearance has grotesquely transformed. Your flesh withers and contracts around your bones, your eyes become sunken, and you reek of death. Regardless of your true form, you're horrific to behold.

You can suspend this form and manifest the appearance of the humanoid you once were, but this is taxing and requires concentration. This form is not permanent, and moments of stress are likely to reveal your true nature. Your true form may be revealed in the following situations:

- Becoming Bloodied
- Concentrating on a spell
- Gaining the Unconscious condition
- Entering hallowed ground
- Choosing to reveal yourself

In these events, or times of other extreme emotional or physical stress, a GM can call for a Constitution Saving Throw with a DC based on your current Transformation Stage:

| Stage | Constitution Save DC |
|-------|----------------------|
| 1     | 10                   |
| 2     | 13                   |
| 3     | 16                   |
| 4     | 20                   |

Non-evil creatures that witness your true form become instantly Hostile to you, unless the GM decides otherwise.

## Lich Stage 3

When you reach Stage 3 of the Lich Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 3 Boon, and also gain the Stage 3 Flaw.

### Stage 3 Boon: Eldritch Concentration

#### *Lich Stage 3 Boon*

Your supernatural ability with magic manifests in new ways. When you cast a spell that requires Concentration, if you are already concentrating on one such spell, you can spend the charge of your soul Vessel. If you do this, you do not lose Concentration on the original spell. Instead, you gain one level of Exhaustion.

If you cast a third Concentration spell during this time, or lose Concentration for any other reason, you lose Concentration on both of the current spells you are concentrating on. Once you use this feature you cannot use it again until you complete a Short or Long rest.

## Stage 3 Boon: Master of Undeath

### *Lich Stage 3 Boon*

#### *Prerequisite: Acolyte of Undeath*

Undead creatures under your control with a Lich Boon have Advantage on their Attack Rolls when they are within 5 feet of you.

Additionally, whenever an undead creature you control with a Lich boon is reduced to 0 hit points, you can spend the charge of your soul vessel as a Reaction. If you do, that undead creature is at 1 hit point instead and may immediately move up to its full speed and make an attack action with Advantage. This feature has no effect if the creature has been reduced to 0 hit points by Radiant damage.

### Stage 3 Boon: Unholy Healing

#### *Lich Stage 3 Boon*

Your magical connection to your soul vessel restores your vitality quickly. While your soul vessel is charged, you can use a Magic action to draw healing power from it. The soul vessel does not lose its charge. At the start of each of your turns for 1 minute, you regain 10 hit points.

You can use this feature three times, and you regain all uses of this feature after completing a Long Rest.

### Stage 3 Flaw: Necromantic Dystrophia

#### *Lich Stage 3 Flaw*

When your soul vessel is not charged, you gain the following effects:

- You cannot use the Dash, Dodge, or Disengage actions.
- You cannot use Reactions.
- You make Constitution Saving Throws with Disadvantage.
- You cannot disguise your Hideous Form feature.

Upon charging your soul vessels with an appropriate soul, you are no longer subject to these effects.

## Lich Stage 4

When you reach Stage 4 of the Lich Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 4 Boon, and also gain the Stage 4 Flaw.

### Stage 4 Boon: Eldritch Omniscience

#### *Lich Stage 4 Boon*

You have better mastered the magical arts. The number of spells you can learn and can have prepared increases by 4. Additionally, whenever you finish a Short or Long Rest you gain 1 additional spell slot of whichever level you choose.

If a creature dies as a result of one of your spells, you can instantly draw that soul into your soul vessel without using an action or Reaction.

### **Stage 4 Boon: Lord of Undeath**

*Lich Stage 4 Boon*

*Prerequisite: Master of Undeath*

When you reduce a Humanoid to 0 hit points and it dies, you can use a Reaction to immediately transform it into a Ghoul instead of a Zombie. You can have three such creatures under your control at once. These creatures follow your verbal commands to the best of their ability.

### **Stage 4 Boon: Soul-Shattering Attack**

*Lich Stage 4 Boon*

When you make a weapon attack, you can spend the charge in your soul vessel to add the Challenge Rating of the soul within it to the attack roll and damage dealt with that attack. If the creature dies from that attack, you can instantly recharge your soul vessel with the soul that you just expended.

You can use this feature a number of times equal to 4 + your Proficiency Bonus. You regain all uses of this feature after completing a Long Rest.

### **Stage 4 Flaw: Weight of the Ages**

*Lich Stage 4 Flaw*

The weight of time is degrading for your form, and only the magic of your soul vessel holds it together. If your soul vessel is reduced to 0 hit points, your soul is lost; you crumble to dust and are killed outright.

# Seraph

Incense burns dimly as muffled coughs echo through the musty room. Loved ones hold each other as a bedridden woman exhales a final breath, her scarred face bearing the mortifying lesions of the Weeping Pox. Her family sobs, too lost in their sorrow to notice how the smoldering embers radiate and shine. A woman with flowing robes and platinum hair approaches from the shadows, radiant energy emanating from her folded, angelic wings. "Hold on for but a moment, my child," she whispers. "Mercy has been granted."

With a thunderous boom, a Seraph's hammer collides with a clot of writhing corpses. Scraps of bone and offal scatter across the dilapidated chapel floor as voices wail in pain. Gritting her teeth, the angelic figure proclaims, "you foul spirits are dead. Begone! I condemn your cadavers to dust!" Golden fire erupts from her hammer as she prepares for another strike.

Seraphs are mortals transformed into Celestial representations of a virtue or ideal. Exalted by a higher power, Seraphs are selected by divine beings after long and patient observation, confirming that the mortal displays pure character. Seraphs are selected from noble martyrs, tireless crusaders, or other exemplary individuals prepared to become the physical manifestation of righteousness.

## Becoming a Seraph

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To be chosen by an Arch-Seraph is to become a vessel for the principles they uphold. This is a charge not to be taken lightly, and those who display righteousness with the intention of becoming a Seraph are usually overlooked for this reason. When becoming a Seraph, consider why your character was chosen. Do you display hidden merit? Are you devoted to a cause they will value?

## Relinquishing Divinity

Characters who reach Stage 1 of the Seraph Transformation do not typically seek power without righteous cause. The Transformation boons and flaws can be removed at any time by relinquishing divinity, as a warrior retires their sword when the war is over. Regaining such power may not be so easy.

## Seraph Stages

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At each stage of this Transformation, follow the instructions provided for that stage.

## Achieving a New Stage

To move from one stage to the next higher one in this Transformation, an event or some other notable occurrence tied to the story of the character should take place. The following events are suggestions for ones that might trigger a move to the next stage of the Transformation:

- Defeat a powerful force of darkness
- Create a hallowed landmark for pilgrims
- Establish a parish of worshipers who uphold your virtue
- Redeem a soul that was considered beyond redemption

## Seraph Stage 1

When you initially undergo the Seraph Transformation, you gain Celestial Form and one other Stage 1 Boon, and also gain the Stage 1 Flaw.

### Stage 1 Boon: Celestial Form

*Seraph Stage 1 Boon*

You become a Celestial in addition to any other creature type(s) you are. Additionally, you have Resistance to Radiant Damage.

### Stage 1 Boon: Angelic Wings

*Seraph Stage 1 Boon*

As a Bonus Action, you can manifest feathered wings for 1 hour. While they are manifested, you have a Fly Speed equal to your speed when you are not wearing heavy armor. Your armor or clothing must be modified to accommodate your wings, which doubles the cost of the clothing or armor.

You can manifest these wings a number of times equal to your Transformation Stage, and you regain all uses after completing a Short or Long Rest.

### Stage 1 Boon: Holy Strikes

*Seraph Stage 1 Boon*

Choose one creature you have just damaged with a weapon attack, Unarmed Attack, or cantrip. You can add 1d6 Radiant damage to that attack. You can add this damage a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus plus your Transformation Stage. You regain all uses of this ability when you finish a Short or Long Rest.

At higher Transformation Stages, you do an additional 1d6 of Radiant damage per Transformation Stage, for a total of 2d6 at Stage 2, 3d6 at Stage 3, and 4d6 at Stage 4.

## Stage 1 Flaw: Planar Binding

### *Seraph Stage 1 Flaw*

Your body and soul are bound to the higher planes of good. You have Disadvantage on Death Saving Throws as the plane attempts to pull your soul into its place of final reward.

## Seraph Stage 2

When you reach Stage 2 of the Seraph Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 2 Boon, and also gain the Stage 2 Flaw.

### Stage 2 Boon: Divine Clemency

#### *Seraph Stage 2 Boon*

When an Ally within 30 feet of you that you can see takes damage, you can use a Reaction to cast *Healing Word* on that Ally without using a spell slot. You can do this a number of times equal to your Transformation Stage. You regain all uses of this ability after completely a Long Rest.

### Stage 2 Boon: Sacred Retribution

#### *Seraph Stage 2 Boon*

When an Ally you can see within 30 feet takes the Attack action with a weapon or Unarmed Strike, you can use your Reaction to imbue them with holy zeal. Immediately after the target completes the attacks made with the Attack action, they can make an additional attack. On a hit, the target takes an additional 1d8 Radiant damage in addition to the regular damage. You may use this feature a number of times equal to your Transformation Stage. You regain all uses of this feature when you finish a Long Rest.

### Stage 2 Flaw: Blinding Radiance

#### *Seraph Stage 2 Flaw*

Your transformation into a Seraph brings with it temporary changes to physical features. Your body radiates a divine glow, and your wings are prominent and unsettling appendages. These might occur under the following circumstances:

- Becoming Bloodied
- Concentrating on a spell
- Gaining the Unconscious condition
- Encountering Elemental creatures or powers
- Using your Seraph Transformation powers for the first time after a Short or Long Rest

In these events, or times of other extreme emotional or physical stress, a GM can call for a Constitution Saving Throw with a DC based on your current Transformation Stage:

| Stage | Constitution Save DC |
|-------|----------------------|
| 1     | 10                   |
| 2     | 13                   |
| 3     | 16                   |
| 4     | 20                   |

When this happens, all non-enemy creatures within 30 feet of you who can see you must succeed on a DC 15 Charisma saving throw or have the Blinded condition for 1 minute. Additionally, attacks against you are made with Advantage for 1 minute.

## Seraph Stage 3

When you reach Stage 3 of the Seraph Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 3 Boon, and also gain the Stage 3 Flaw.

### Stage 3 Boon: Cleanse Affliction

#### *Seraph Stage 3 Boon*

##### *Prerequisite: Divine Clemency*

When you use Divine Clemency on a creature, they gain the following benefits as well:

- They gain Temporary Hit Points equal to the amount of damage healed by the Divine Clemency.
- They have Advantage on their next D20 Test made within the next minute.
- You end one of the following conditions on it: Blinded, Deafened, Paralyzed, or Poisoned.

### Stage 3 Boon: Protective Wings

#### *Seraph Stage 3 Boon*

##### *Prerequisite: Angelic Wings*

While your Angelic Wings are manifested, you gain the following benefits:

- As a Reaction when you or an Ally within 5 feet of you is targeted by a weapon attack, you can impose Disadvantage on that attack. If the attack hits the Ally, you can take half the damage that the Ally would have taken, leaving them to take half damage as well.
- You have advantage on saving throws or ability checks to avoid gaining the Grappled condition or to escape a Grapple.
- Your Fly Speed is increased by 10 feet.

### Stage 3 Boon: Bow of Celestial Judgement

#### *Seraph Stage 3 Boon*

You can use a Bonus Action to manifest a powerful bow made of divine light. The Bow of Celestial Judgement lasts for 1 minute and grants you the following abilities while manifested:

- You can use a Magic action to target a creature you can see within 120 feet with your bow. The creature must succeed on a Dexterity saving throw against a DC equal to 8 + your Proficiency Bonus + your Transformation Stage. On a failed save, the creature takes 6d6 Radiant damage, or 10d6 if it is a Fey, Fiend, or Undead. On a successful, the creature takes half damage.
- You are Resistant to Necrotic damage.
- You gain 5 Temporary Hit Points at the start of each of your turns.

You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Transformation Stage, and you regain all uses after completing a Long Rest.

### Stage 3 Flaw: Beacon to Darkness

#### *Seraph Stage 3 Flaw*

You have become a Seraph of noted virtue and divinity. This has made you a target for all that is dark in the world. Whenever you or an Ally within 30 feet commits an act of evil, such as murdering an innocent, a small amount of darkness attaches itself to you and you have the Corrupted condition. Whether the act constitutes as evil is determined by the GM.

While you have the Corrupted condition, whenever you make an attack roll against an evil creature or a saving throw against a spell or ability from an evil creature, you have Disadvantage on the check. Also, if an Allied creature is the one who caused your Corruption, they cannot be considered your Ally or you theirs until the Corrupted condition is removed.

You can remove the Corrupted condition by completing a Short or Long Rest. During that rest you must pray for at least 1 hour and donate wealth to a local good cause with a gold-piece value of at least 100 gp times your Transformation Stage.

## Seraph Stage 4

When you reach Stage 4 of the Seraph Transformation, you select one appropriate Stage 4 Boon, and also gain the Stage 4 Flaw.

### Stage 4 Boon: Aura of Holy Purge

#### *Seraph Stage 4 Boon*

You emit an aura of righteous fervor while you are conscious. Allies within a 20-foot sphere centered on you gain the following benefit:

- When an Ally within the aura hits an enemy creature with a weapon, they can use a Reaction and choose for that hit to be a critical hit instead. The Ally and you then gain a level of Exhaustion.

Each Ally can use this ability once, and it cannot be used again until the Ally completes a Long Rest.

### Stage 4 Boon: Aura of Righteous Mercy

#### *Seraph Stage 4 Boon*

You emit an aura of peaceful resolution while you are conscious. Allies within a 20-foot sphere centered on you gain the following benefit:

- When an Ally would be reduced to 0 Hit Points, they can use a Reaction to be reduced to 1 Hit Point instead. The Ally and you then gain a level of Exhaustion. Each Ally can use this ability once, and it cannot be used again until the Ally completes a Long Rest.

### Stage 4 Boon: Bow of Celestial Domination

#### *Seraph Stage 4 Boon*

#### *Prerequisite: Bow of Celestial Judgement*

While your Bow of Celestial Judgement is manifested, you gain these additional benefits:

- When you use the Magic action to target a creature you can see within 120 feet with your bow, you can also affect one other creature with 10 feet of the original target.
- You are Immune to Necrotic damage instead of Resistant.
- You gain 15 Temporary Hit Points at the start of each of your turns instead of 5.

### Stage 4 Flaw: Seraph Corruption

#### *Seraph Stage 4 Flaw*

The weight of evil in the world weighs on you more and more heavily as the days pass. Sometimes it becomes too much, and your celestial form is wracked with pain and doubt.

Whenever you roll a natural 1 for a saving throw, you gain the Corrupted condition for 1 minute. During that time, you suffer the following:

- At the start of each of your turns, you take 1d10 Psychic damage. That damage cannot be reduced in any way.
- You cannot regain Hit Points or have Temporary Hit Points.
- The first attack roll you make on each of your turns is made with Disadvantage.
- The first creature who makes a saving throw against one of your spells, powers, or abilities on each of your turns has Advantage on the save.